sources. If anything, Farhadi told Spengler, the Afghans were apprehensive of potential 'Indian expansionism' and did not want to see Pakistan disintegrate as that would only increase the 'danger' to Afghanistan.[39] When pressed by Spengler as to explain the exact nature of this 'danger', Farhadi retorted that an Indian 'Anschluss' against Pakistan at some point in the future could not be disregarded.[40] A coup against Ayub Khan, initiated by select Punjabi leaders and Sindhi nationalists, Farhadi reasoned, could lead to the creation of a South Asian 'federation' jeopardising Afghan claims on Pashtunistan. However unlikely this was, the conversation highlighted Kabul's concerns on Pashtunistan and Kashmir. Whether this was a calculated ploy to get Islamabad to the negotiating table on a bilateral dispute when it was under stress and seek concessions remains unclear, but Kabul did not view a powerful and assertive India as a preferred neighbour over Pakistan. If Islamabad, the relatively weaker of the two states, had not budged on the issue of Pashtunistan, then why would India? When asked about his views on potential disintegration of Pakistan, Farhadi had rhetorically replied: 'do you think we would want India at the Khyber Pass?'.[41] In this context, it is difficult to assess who was bluffing on the statement of the Afghan king's sympathy towards Pakistan—Bhutto or Zahir Shah? Though India officially blamed Bhutto, it is entirely possible that Zahir Shah did make such a statement in private, and then seeing that Pakistan's military momentum was ebbing, and India's desire for a bilateral ceasefire, denied it. The complexity (and evolution) of Afghan political opinion on the 1965 war is best reflected in Farhadi personally assuring the Indian ambassador in Kabul that Zahir Shah had not issued a statement of support to Ayub Khan, either verbally or in writing, just a few days after criticising India's 'expansionist' tendencies to Spengler.[42] Indeed, in October 1965, when Pakistan's military gambit failed to reap strategic benefits, Afghanistan, in a diplomatic U-turn, joined India's advocacy on the right to self-determination for Pashtuns and Baloch.[43] Friendship between India and Afghanistan survived the upheaval of 1965. To mend differences, Indian Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri was to visit Kabul two days after signing the Tashkent Declaration (but could not due to his untimely death).[44] Nonetheless, in July 1966, India's Vice President Dr. Zakir Hussain visited Kabul to set the stage for mutually beneficial economic cooperation.[45]